STATUS REPORT

Nigeria — digital transformation and data governance status report

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GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

Nigeria adopted a sovereign cloud regime in August 2026 that nobody outside government can read: NITDA signed the National Cloud Computing Guideline, the National Cloud Technical Guideline and the National Digital Infrastructure Assurance Framework on 4 August 2026, and none of them was published at the ceremony or retrievable afterwards; the instruments set data-classification and provider-certification requirements, with Galaxy Backbone as delivery operator. The instrument they rest on is older than the market it governs — Nigeria's national telecommunications policy has not been revised since 2000, and the Nigerian Communications Commission is rewriting it because a licensing regime built for voice and SMS does not fit cloud, artificial intelligence and data centres.

Who owns delivery is the live question. The communications minister paused enforcement of new internet-platform rules pending a unified digital-economy framework and convened a joint NCC, NITDA and NDPC technical committee to resolve overlapping mandates, and the interim settlement of the digital-lending dispute is a ministerial direction rather than an instrument, with operators asking both regulators for coordination protocols.

The digital public infrastructure programme is the most explicit commitment on paper. A framework covering identity, payments and data exchange names the national digital exchange as the data backbone, with a target of 75 per cent of public services digitised by 2027 on an integrated-government model (March 2025), and a Presidential Committee on DPI Implementation chaired by the President was inaugurated in May 2025 to coordinate it. The Government Service Portal sits inside the e-Government Master Plan 2.0 and has been piloted since 2025 with a few agencies. In payments, the Central Bank replaced its five-year planning horizon with the three-year Payments System Vision 2028, while none of its fintech roadmap — a Single Regulatory Window, cross-border passporting pilots, a Responsible AI in Finance Hub — is in force (February 2026). The overarching document remains the ministry's 2023 Strategic Blueprint. Behind the documents, Nigeria ranks 33rd of 54 African states on the Mo Ibrahim Foundation's expert-assessed governance index, down 1.4 points over the decade to 2023, with 47 of its 96 indicators improving and 45 declining.

Legislation and regulation

Nigeria's newest identity statute is in force and cannot be read: the National Identity Management Commission Act 2026 was signed into law on 26 June 2026, repealing the 2007 Act and making the National Identification Number the country's foundational credential under a "one person, one identity" policy, while its gazetted text had still not been published at the end of July 2026, six weeks after assent. The general statutes are older: the Cybercrimes Act 2015 remains the principal cybercrime law and the Nigeria Data Protection Act 2023 the general law on personal data.

Virtual assets moved from prohibition to a coordinated perimeter. The Investments and Securities Act 2025 brought crypto assets under SEC securities law, and a Presidential Executive Order on Virtual Assets Coordination signed in July 2026 created a Virtual Asset Council chaired by the Central Bank of Nigeria with the Nigeria Revenue Service and the Securities and Exchange Commission as vice-chairs — an order that creates no new regulator and transfers no powers, registration following the activity. Taxation arrived ahead of licensing: the Revenue Service's Information Circular No. 2026/21 of 31 July 2026 is the first comprehensive virtual-asset tax framework, and its 1.5% stamp duty on transfers is withheld in the asset itself, so the federal government now takes Bitcoin and USDT as revenue and carries the price risk on it, while a wallet-to-wallet peer-to-peer trade has no collection agent at all.

The gaps sit where the state has legislated by bill. The National Digital Economy and E-Governance Bill 2024, which would make NITDA a super-regulator, reached public hearing in November 2025 unenacted; four consolidated artificial-intelligence bills passed second reading on 3 December 2024 and no AI statute has followed; SB.648, which would oblige large platforms to keep offices in Nigeria, went to a Senate hearing on 23 July 2026 and has not passed. Where regulators filled a gap they collided: the Federal High Court upheld the FCCPC's digital-lending regulations while holding airtime lending to be exclusively the NCC's, and the appeal was before the Court of Appeal in August 2026 with no joint framework published.

Data protection

A Nigerian court has awarded damages for a data-protection breach for the first time, and the regulator was not involved: on 29 July 2026 the FCT High Court gave judgment against Stanbic IBTC for marketing to a customer after consent was withdrawn, awarding ₦15,000,000 in general damages and ₦500,000 costs. Liability rested on the Data Protection Act, section 37 of the 1999 Constitution and the Federal Competition and Consumer Protection Act together, the court treating post-withdrawal marketing as an unfair trade practice and refusing wholesale deletion where banking and anti-money-laundering retention duties apply. The private route reaches the state too: digital-rights lawyers sued the Independent National Electoral Commission in July 2026 for having no published privacy policy.

The commission's perimeter widened in the same month. The Federal High Court upheld its power to designate and register Data Controllers and Processors of Major Importance, dismissing a suit that sought to place PoS agents outside that class, after which the commission issued a fresh registration directive reaching PoS agents, banks, telecoms operators, health providers and digital platforms. Its implementing rules sit in the General Application and Implementation Directive of March 2025; transfers abroad require adequate protection rather than localisation, and the United States is not a recognised destination.

Enforcement runs by sweep. Compliance notices went to 1,369 organisations in August 2025 and to more than 1,000 educational institutions in February 2026, with investigations opened into TikTok and Truecaller, Temu and Sterling Bank. The largest penalty remains ₦766,242,500, about US$501,000 in July 2025, on MultiChoice Nigeria for want of cooperation after directed remediation was judged unsatisfactory. Public bodies are the weak point: a circular of 27 July 2026 ordered every ministry and agency to appoint a data protection officer and file audit returns, but no copy was on the Secretary to the Government's own portal three days after the commission announced it, the most recent one there dating from November 2022 and imposing the same duties. Cross River State has approved a facial-recognition and licence-plate network feeding the Office of the State Security Adviser, naming no lawful basis, retention period or oversight arrangement.

Regional collaboration

The regional perimeter Nigeria's digital commitments run through has stopped covering West Africa: Burkina Faso, Mali and Niger severed ECOWAS ties in 2024, taking themselves out of the WURI regional identity programme, and have built a rival Alliance of Sahel States with a common biometric passport from January 2025 and AES-aligned national ID cards in Burkina Faso from November 2025 and Niger from March 2026.

What binds Nigeria inside ECOWAS is largely unpublished or unfunded. Ministers adopted the ECOWAS Digital Sector Development Strategy 2024-2029 in Cotonou on 4 October 2024, with a directive on cyber and ICT confidence-building measures that member states were to implement on its publication — the same meeting required full implementation of the ECOWAS Roaming Regulation by every mobile operator by the end of 2025, a deadline binding on Nigeria's networks. ECOWAS then adopted a digital roadmap in Lagos in January 2026 committing members to a Regional Digital Single Market for more than 400 million citizens through fintech, identity and broadband. None of it is paid for from the levy Nigeria contributes: the Community MTEF Budget 2026-2028 carries no disaggregated digital or ICT appropriation, and its only ICT-named programme line shows nil from 2024 through 2028. The regional finance that exists went elsewhere — the World Bank's US$137m second West Africa Regional Digital Integration Project covers Benin, Liberia and Sierra Leone (March 2026).

The reach that has been built is credential-deep rather than system-deep, though the wider measures moved: Nigeria's regional integration score rose 16.5 points over the decade to 2023, to 20th of 54 African states — the sixth-largest gain of the Ibrahim Index's 96 indicators for Nigeria. Nigeria unveiled the ECOWAS biometric national identity card in Abuja on 28 November 2025; the AfCFTA Secretariat picked Nigeria, Kenya and Morocco as the first pilots for shared cross-border rails for identity, payments and trusted data exchange (May 2026); and Nigeria joined the Global Cross-Border Privacy Rules Forum as an associate member in April 2025. The West Africa Telecommunications Regulators Assembly finalised harmonisation reports on 5G, subsea-cable resilience, cybersecurity and satellite regulation in April 2026.

Standards

Nigeria has written itself a procurement gate for software that does not yet close: NITDA approved a National Software Quality Assurance Framework in July 2026 under which every government software project must be independently tested and certified before go-live, certification being a mandatory condition of NITDA IT Project Clearance, with systems tiered by risk — Class A covering core banking, national identity infrastructure and power-grid control — and the Software Development Guideline requiring OWASP-based secure coding and WCAG 2.1 AA conformance for citizen-facing platforms. It does not reach full operation until Q2 2027, and as at July 2026 no Licensed Software Testing Organisation existed to do the testing.

The binding standards work is in telecoms. The Cyber Resilience Framework for the Nigeria Communication Sector took effect on 23 February 2026 and is enforceable on every licensee, not only the large operators, built on five pillars expanded into individually coded standards with annexed reporting templates; incident reporting is a timed three-part obligation of detection within four hours, confirmation within twenty-four and updates every four hours thereafter, its severity matrix treats a breach of sensitive personal data as critical, and compliance is staged to fall due in full on 23 February 2027. An updated NCC guidance note of 7 August 2026 adds a dedicated cybersecurity budget line, a chief information security officer, board-level cyber risk and periodic audit for every licensed operator.

Across government the shared-standards layer is thinner and older. The e-Government Interoperability Framework dates from 2019, the DPI Technical Standard makes the National Identification Number the primary identifier across government systems, and NITDA's draft DPI technical standards covering identity, payments and data exchange went out for consultation in April 2025. In payments, the Central Bank required all PoS terminals to be geo-tagged and the industry to migrate to ISO 20022 messaging from October 2025. Where nothing shared exists, systems are built one at a time: tertiary institutions are drafting their own AI guidelines in the absence of a national framework, and the courts are digitising without a national judicial technology strategy.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

A presidential candidate is on trial for social-media posts: Omoyele Sowore is being prosecuted at the Federal High Court in Abuja under section 24 of the Cybercrimes (Amendment) Act 2024 over posts of 25 August 2025, pleaded not guilty on 2 December 2025, and the case stood adjourned to 28 September 2026 with the Department of State Services applying to foreclose his defence after a single defence witness. The DSS also demanded that X and Meta ban the accounts and remove the posts; both were co-defendants before being delisted in the amended charge. Section 24 continues to be used against journalists (February 2026). Over the decade to 2023, Nigeria's digital freedom — expert coding of online censorship, shutdowns and state manipulation of social media — fell 14.6 points, leaving it 26th of 54 African states, while media freedom at 32nd fell 4.8 points and the formal freedom of expression held flat.

Where consultation happens, it happens late and about the wrong thing. The Senate held its public hearing on SB.648, the platform-offices bill, on 23 July 2026, and its sponsor opened a public consultation on Facebook on 27 July 2026 — after the hearing rather than before it. Civil-society groups had already opposed the amendment on 18 July 2026, warning that its enforcement powers could be used to block platforms, while a youth-led coalition backed passage at the same hearing without contesting a single provision.

There is no standing channel for any of this. The GovTech Maturity Index records no government platform for citizen participation in policy or decision-making, returning "No" on the indicator and all six sub-indicators (2025), against right-to-information legislation the same index rates in force and effective. The accessibility of public records is among Nigeria's strongest placings anywhere in the Ibrahim Index, and one of its largest ten-year gains, while what the state proactively discloses has barely moved over the decade to 2023. Proposals to build a channel sit outside government: a civil-society framework pairing radio, SMS and USSD with digital platforms for National Assembly hearings sits unadopted at draft stage (August 2026).

Finance

MoUs and other agreements

The December 2025 health memorandum between the United States and Nigeria says in its own text that it is not an international agreement and that the support it sets out is subject to the availability of funds, and it names an American cloud supplier for the national insurance claims database as an example rather than a concluded contract.

Where money is attached, the sums are small. The United States and Nigeria signed a US$2 million grant toward the 90,000 km fibre build at their first technology dialogue in Washington in January 2025, and the Nigerian Communications Commission signed a grant agreement with Swedfund in February 2025 for a crowdsourced project generating real-time network performance data. Nigeria and Finland signed a memorandum on digitalisation and innovation in March 2026 covering cybersecurity, digital governance and digital infrastructure, with Finnish participation in Project BRIDGE through Finnvera and Finnfund still prospective. Nigeria's space agency signed a memorandum with China's Galaxy Space for direct-to-device satellite connectivity, with technology transfer and engineer training attached, and a subsea fibre agreement with Equatorial Guinea extends the regional reach.

Domestically the memorandum is the instrument of choice too: police stations are to be mapped and connected to the national backbone under one, agricultural statistics harmonised between the agricultural development fund and the statistics office under another, and NITDA's route to placing vetted Nigerian technology professionals into remote work abroad rests on a partnership rather than a contract. Company announcements run the same way, from a five-area artificial intelligence alliance with Google opened by the president in Paris to a Tether partnership supplying stablecoin liquidity to the business customers of the Nigerian exchange Busha.

New investments

Nigeria's largest single digital commitment has moved no money at all: the US$500 million World Bank credit behind Project BRIDGE had disbursed US$0.00, or 0%, as at 24 July 2026, approved in October 2025, signed that December and effective on 27 April 2026 against a 2030 closing date. It anchors a US$800 million sovereign package — US$500 million World Bank, US$200 million African Development Bank, US$100 million EBRD, of which the EBRD's is a sovereign loan of up to US$100 million into the project company and the AfDB's was approved in April 2026.

Behind that sits about US$5 billion of external and private commitment across 70 distinct deals recorded between 2015 and 2026. The World Bank is the largest financier, ahead of the African Development Bank, out of 39 in all. Equity is the commonest instrument, at 30 of the 70 commitments, while the largest individual sums arrive as sovereign concessional credit. Connectivity absorbs the most, ahead of the ICT industry and of payments, which is the most numerous subsector at 19 commitments, and just over half of all commitments go to private recipients rather than to government.

The identity money is nearly spent. The US$430 million ID4D package approved in February 2020 — US$115 million IDA, US$100 million from Agence Française de Développement and US$215 million from the European Investment Bank was restructured in December 2024, lifting the enrolment target and pushing the closing date to 31 December 2026 with about 53% of funds disbursed. Newer money arrives on other terms: JICA signed a ¥3.142 billion grant in February 2026, about US$21 million at signature, seeding a US$50 million startup fund with the sovereign wealth fund; the European Union committed €45 million in December 2025; the IFC lent US$150 million to Airtel Africa in July 2026; and Dimension Data closed a ₦4.05 billion first tranche of a ₦20 billion bond on 27 July 2026, the first domestic-bond financing of a Nigerian fibre build. Foreign direct investment into telecoms ran at US$392.91 million over the first nine months of 2025, against US$456.6 million for 2024.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Nigeria's flagship fibre programme had built nothing at all by the middle of 2026: as at 24 July 2026 Project BRIDGE had added none of its 90,000 km fibre target, raised none of its US$1,100m private-capital target and signed none of its 25 planned client contracts. It is building from a thin base: the same financier's appraisal of September 2025 put terrestrial fibre deployed at 30,000 km against the 120,000 km the national blueprint requires, and stated flatly that there is no national backbone network, while its statement at Board approval framed the programme as laying over 90,000 km of fibre and extending the national backbone from 35,000 km to 125,000 km. What is already in the ground is being destroyed faster than it is being protected: the regulator put fibre-optic cable cuts from road works at more than 5,000 in the first half of 2026, and stood up a standing committee with the works and communications ministries and the National Security Adviser's office to coordinate protection of fibre designated as critical national information infrastructure. No terms of reference, meeting cycle, budget or enforcement power is published for that committee. The company meant to do the building was incorporated as Bridge Open Access, announced on 10 August 2026: a vehicle in which private investors are to hold 51% to 75% against the Federal Government's 25% to 49%, running as a wholesale open-access provider rather than a new retail operator. The World Bank's appraisal of September 2025 sets US$500m of IDA credit against US$1,100m of commercial financing and rates fiduciary risk High.

The existing network carried 188m active subscriptions in April 2026, with broadband penetration at 55.67% and teledensity at 86.73%, up from 50% broadband penetration in November 2025, 4G accounting for 54.41% of connections and 5G for 4.34%. Population coverage stood at 2G 95.31%, 3G 89.42%, 4G 84.60% and 5G 13.28% in December 2024, against the regulator's own 2030 targets of at least 96% for 4G and at least 50% for 5G. 5G's problem is not handsets: only 31.4% of 5G-capable devices in Abuja and 27.5% in Lagos were using 5G in February 2026, unchanged from August 2025 even as the capable-device base grew. The network has outrun its use: Nigeria's mobile communications score in the Ibrahim Index made the largest ten-year improvement of any of its 96 indicators, to 14th of 54 African states, while internet use, affordability and computer access reached only 31st, at less than half that score (2023).

Fixed broadband median download speed reached 39.93 Mbps at 7 July 2026, against 22.15 Mbps in January 2025, and peering at Nigeria's internet exchange grew from 4 Gbps in 2015 to a peak of 1.7 Tbps by early 2026. Money came back after the Commission approved a 50% tariff increase in January 2025, the first in eleven years: MTN Nigeria reported profit after tax of ₦707.54bn for the half year to 30 June 2026. What that money buys keeps being cut, stolen and locked out.

Data Storage

Nigerian banks and payment providers must hold their transaction data onshore from next year, under a Central Bank circular of June 2026 ordering localisation of payments data by 2027. No global hyperscaler runs a full cloud region in the country to hold it. Amazon Web Services' only African region is in Cape Town, with Nigeria served from there and from edge infrastructure; the nearest local presence is an AWS Local Zone in Lagos, in place since 2023, with an expanded 100G Direct Connect from September 2025; and hyperscaler region investment has gone to Kenya and South Africa instead.

Around 26 facilities, 18 of them commercial, carried 50 to 56 MW of live capacity in July 2026, making Nigeria Africa's second-largest data-centre market after South Africa at about 15% of continental capacity — a figure that reaches roughly 124 MW only when operators' design specifications are counted alongside declared capacity, and which an independent research house measuring only capacity active, under lease or readily available for lease puts lower still, at about 28 MW across some 15 live facilities against about 80 MW at full build (January 2026). Almost all of it sits in Lagos, with diversification only beginning through Galaxy Backbone's Abuja and Kano sites and Equinix's Port Harcourt facility. Additions have come quickly: MTN's US$235m Sifiso Dabengwa centre, a Tier III first phase of 780 racks and 4.5 MW (July 2025), Digital Realty's 2 MW LKK2 at Lekki (August 2025), Equinix's US$22m LG3 (November 2025) and Kasi Cloud's US$250m campus at Lekki, backed by the sovereign wealth fund (February 2026).

Localisation is sectoral rather than statutory, and since August 2026 it is graded. NITDA's National Cloud Policy 2025 sets residency and hosting requirements for sensitive sovereign data, and the National Digital Cloud Policy issued on 17 August 2026 sorts government and regulated data into four levels — national-security data on infrastructure in Nigeria only, financial, health, biometric and identity data stored at rest in Nigeria, internal operational records hybrid by prior authorisation, and public data unrestricted — while making cloud the default for new federal systems and leaving commercial data under no general localisation duty, its sovereignty provisions awaiting presidential approval; telecommunications subscriber data and government sovereign data are already required to sit in Nigeria; and the NCC's August 2026 guidance adds two years of in-country retention for call logs and traffic data. The National Sovereign Cloud Initiative is meant to keep government data inside national jurisdiction and under local operational control, NITDA naming cable cuts and outages at international providers as the systemic risk to banking, healthcare and agriculture while inviting hyperscalers to build in Nigeria — the case resting on the March 2024 damage to four West African cables. Operators say racks are not the binding constraint: what is missing is local cloud-compute and storage able to replace AWS, Azure and Google, along with power and engineers.

Energy

The telecoms regulator has stopped waiting for the grid: it has agreed with the Rural Electrification Agency to power base stations and fibre repeaters from off-grid renewable installations and to co-locate telecommunications equipment on the agency's energy assets (July 2026), building on the mini-grids the agency already runs under an Off-Grid Electrification Strategy, on regulations the electricity regulator made in 2016. What that routes around is a grid that has never reliably carried more than 6 GW for a population of about 230 million, roughly 41% availability (May 2026), with 61.2% of the population having access to electricity in 2023 and rural access far below urban. Connection is the part that has moved: Nigeria's access to energy score in the Ibrahim Index rose 13.6 points over 2014-2023, one of the ten largest improvements among the 96 indicators it tracks for the country, and still leaves it 26th of 54 African states (2023).

For the firms that would build a digital economy the constraint shows up as interruptions rather than price: a survey of Nigerian technology companies recorded more than 30 outages a month (2025), and unreliable electricity sits beside unreliable connectivity as a named barrier to electronic health record adoption in Nigerian hospitals (2026). What the grid does not carry, diesel does, at a cost per unit several times grid power in South Africa and Kenya — which is why live data-centre capacity grows more slowly than the announcements, and why operators name power reliability alongside skills as the gap.

Technical Capacity

The World Bank twice flagged weak capacity at the ministry implementing Nigeria's flagship fibre programme, rating the operation's environmental and social risk Substantial and requiring an environmental and social expert in place throughout — a judgement about the department that must now supervise the national fibre build. The telecoms regulator has made a comparable admission about its own delivery, conceding that a digital industrial park and learning centre it financed and built at Enugu were never activated. Both sit inside a longer decline: public administration is the sub-category in which Nigeria has fallen furthest within the Ibrahim Index's Foundations for Economic Opportunity, down 6.6 points over 2014-2023 to 37th of 54 African states, so the administrative capacity digital systems are built on weakened across the decade in which they were built. The component moving the other way is the state's own effectiveness at delivery, up 9.2 points to 30th of 54 — the only substantial improvement among that sub-category's indicators (2023).

The private pipeline reads differently. Nigeria had more than 1.1 million GitHub developer accounts in 2024, growing 28% year on year — the largest developer community in Africa and the fastest growth among the world's most populous countries. Public-sector engineering has begun to follow: the national identity register now runs on a platform NIMC built and manages itself, replacing its previous vendor arrangement, and a start-up hub in Abuja is being built for NITDA with Japanese funding. The constraint operators name is not design capability but depth: alongside power, skilled engineers are what the data-centre estate says it lacks.

Cybersecurity

Every Nigerian telecoms licensee has been bound since 23 February 2026 by a Cyber Resilience Framework for the communications sector, with full compliance due 23 February 2027, under which a breach involving sensitive personal information is a Critical incident, to be notified to the regulator's own response team within four hours of detection and confirmed within 24 — a shorter clock than the one the Data Protection Act runs, and to a different body. Nothing in it requires an incident ever to be named publicly: its information-sharing centre circulates threat intelligence among providers and national bodies, and reporting runs to regulators.

Governance is crowded rather than thin: sector cybersecurity is split across four existing bodies — the NCC with its own response team, ngCERT as national technical coordination, the National Cybersecurity Coordination Centre under the 2021 policy, and the data-protection commission under the 2023 Act — and the framework creates two more. The governing strategy dates from 2021, and the root certification authority role moved from NITDA to the identity commission, with NITDA's public key infrastructure, in July 2026. The ITU's Global Cybersecurity Index 2024 places Nigeria in its third tier, legal measures its strongest pillar at 19.52 out of 20 and organisational measures, capacity development and international cooperation weaker: the shape of a state that legislates faster than it staffs.

The Nigeria Police Force National Cybercrime Centre was named INTERPOL's best cybercrime unit in Africa for 2024, first of 54 assessed; the securities regulator, central bank and financial-crimes commission jointly track and freeze illicit digital wallets (November 2025); since March 2026 financial institutions must run automated monitoring for money laundering and terrorist financing; and a 2024 order designates the bank verification and national identification databases as critical national information infrastructure. The data-protection commission puts attacks at more than 4,000 a week and cybercrime losses at about ₦12bn for 2024. The attack that lands most often is still physical: operators recorded 19,384 fibre cuts, 3,241 equipment thefts and more than 19,000 site-access denials between January and August 2025. Nigeria has no established domestic cyber-insurance market to price any of it.

DPI

Data Exchange

Nigeria's inter-agency data exchange began carrying live personal data on 30 July 2026, when the Government Service Portal went into service integrated with the Nigerian Digital Exchange, so that federal agencies read a citizen's details from one another rather than each collecting them again. The exchange beneath it was unveiled in August 2025, built with the European Union, Finland and Estonia and targeted to be operational by the end of that year, on an architecture modelled on Estonia's X-Road whose first sector use cases were expected from 2026.

What it has to join up is eight federal registers — identity, banking, telecoms subscriber, immigration, tax, road safety, corporate and voter — that do not interoperate, leaving citizens to present the same details and biometrics to each agency in turn, and they were still siloed in June 2026, which is the constraint the exchange work exists to lift rather than a problem it has solved.

The shared plumbing changed hands in the same period: NITDA took the Nigeria Government Enterprise Architecture over from Korea's KOICA in March 2026 after two and a half years of construction under the e-Government Master Plan 2.0, and it is hosted by the state carrier Galaxy Backbone and piloted at NIMC, the Customs Service, the Immigration Service and NITDA.

Where exchange works today it is sectoral. A company's Corporate Affairs Commission number has functioned as its tax identifier since 1 January 2026, with the revenue service's database integrated with the corporate register for new registrations. The National Single Window has replaced duplicate paperwork across agencies with a single customs submission since 27 March 2026, with electronic vessel manifests advancing as the next phase over the objection of licensed customs agents. An April 2026 arrangement between the central bank and the telecoms regulator gives banks a telecom feed to check for SIM swaps and recycled numbers before clearing a transaction, and consented sharing of customer banking data on tied consent, a central registry and standard interfaces was approved for an August 2025 launch.

Digital Identity and CRVS

Enrolment in the national identity register passed 136 million by July 2026, up from 123.9 million in October 2025, still short of the 180 million the World Bank-financed identity project targets on a timetable now extended to December 2026. The register skews male and urban: 56.25% men to 43.75% women at October 2025, led by Lagos with 13.1 million, Kano with 11.5 million and Kaduna with 7.3 million.

The identity statute passed in 2026 turns the identity commission into infrastructure for the rest of government: it becomes Nigeria's root certification authority for electronic signatures and digital trust services, and it folds cyber-enforcement into the identity system, with a reactivated inspectorate and compliance unit working against illegal enrolment centres, identity theft and online fraud and the data protection act incorporated into the Act.

The number now gates ordinary life. A functional identity number is required for healthcare, education, banking, employment, telecoms and welfare; health insurance enrolment has required it since 1 January 2026; and satellite internet users were required to submit a number and a headshot by December 2025. Legal identity now begins with it too: registering a newborn requires at least one parent to hold a valid number, and a child registered at birth is issued one automatically where connectivity allows.

The route back is narrower than the route in: corrections to a record run through a device-locked smartphone portal in a country where 72% of adults have no smartphone, pushing people into paid workarounds (March 2026). Over the same decade the register grew, Nigerians' own rating of how easy it is to obtain an identity document fell steeply, one of the country's ten most deteriorated governance indicators and 34th of 54 African states (2023).

Outward, the credential travels further than it did. Nigeria began issuing the ECOWAS biometric identity card on 28 November 2025, linked to the national number and valid for travel across the bloc without a passport, and completed integration with the ICAO Public Key Directory in July 2026, moving its passports from machine-readable to cryptographically verifiable at any member state's border.

Digital Payments and Fintech

The IMF found in June 2026 that Nigerians' shift into dollar-linked stablecoins is weakening demand for the naira and blunting the transmission of monetary policy, which makes retail crypto adoption a monetary-sovereignty question rather than a consumer-protection one. The scale behind that finding is US$59bn of crypto-asset inflows between July 2023 and June 2024, second place globally on the 2024 adoption index and sixth in 2025, and around 60% of sub-Saharan Africa's stablecoin inflows since 2019.

The domestic rails are old and heavily used. The instant payment scheme has run since 2011 and handled around 11 billion transactions in 2024, and electronic transactions were worth ₦1.2 quadrillion in 2025, against ₦395 trillion in 2022. The first live transaction on a next-generation National Payment Stack, built to ISO 20022, settled on 7 November 2025. Who decides how that rail runs is narrower than who uses it — the scheme is governed by a board of central bank and bank representatives, with no consumer advisory body, no seats for small payment providers or fintechs and no financial inclusion mandate in its charter. Access to banking services ranks Nigeria 12th of 54 in Africa and barely improved over 2014-2023, at a level that leaves most adults outside a bank (2023).

The state's own digital currency has gone the other way: the eNaira is being redesigned toward a wholesale model in which licensed institutions hold the customer relationship. Virtual assets are handled by coordination rather than consolidation: an executive order establishes a Virtual Asset Council chaired by the central bank with the revenue service and the securities commission as vice-chairs, and a shared supervisory-technology platform, while creating no new regulator and transferring no statutory power.

Telco fintech proved thinner than its billing suggested. MTN Nigeria's fintech revenue fell 72.4% year on year to ₦12.99 billion in the second quarter of 2026 after it suspended its airtime and data credit service, a single withdrawn product that cost 1.4 percentage points of group service-revenue growth in the half and has since resumed on four vendors with the lending base cut to about a quarter of its first-quarter run rate, at a stated cost of about ₦50 billion (US$37.1 million) to first-half revenue, while mobile money revenue grew about 132% and active wallets rose 1.3 million to 5.0 million.

Registries

Just over 12.3 million of the more than 77 million individuals on the National Social Register had been linked to a National Identification Number by May 2026, of which over 11.5 million were validated — the country's largest functional register is still substantially unjoined to the identity spine it is meant to sit on.

The register's own reach is wide: over 70 million individuals in more than 19 million households across all 36 states, the Federal Capital Territory and all 774 local government areas (2026), grown in part by expanding it from 13 million to 19.7 million households using artificial intelligence, satellite imagery and telecoms data to find urban slum households. Independent analysis puts that at 69.94 million people, 52.6% of the multidimensionally poor population (2025).

Civil registration went national on paper before it went national in fact: the electronic civil registration and vital statistics platform went live nationwide on 1 July 2026, covering births and stillbirths, adoption, marriage and divorce notification, migration and death, delivered through 4,011 registration centres against a target of about 8,000 and run as a public-private partnership with a Nigerian technology provider carrying availability, security and administration. The population commission has asked state governments to fund their own state-wide rollouts, with Akwa Ibom the first state to begin. The decade behind it ran the other way: Nigeria's civil registration score in the Ibrahim Index fell 12.5 points over 2014-2023, to 50.0 of 100 and 31st of 54 African states, the largest fall of any of its public administration measures (2023).

Property and companies are the thin registers. Less than 5% of land is formally titled and over 90% remains unregistered (2025), against which the federal government has launched a national land registration and documentation programme to digitise land records. Only 9% of companies registered in Nigeria were captured in the tax system in February 2025, a gap the automatic use of corporate registration numbers as tax identifiers from January 2026 is built to close.

Sectoral management information systems

The human-resource modules of the federal payroll and personnel system went live on 27 July 2026, serving over 508 ministries, departments and agencies and more than 600,000 civil servants, who can now manage their records, download payslips and apply for leave online; the same system remitted ₦1.96 trillion for those agencies in 2024.

The administrative core is complete in inventory and thin in depth. Nigeria runs live systems across all nine core functions the World Bank assesses, and every one whose software type is recorded runs on commercial off-the-shelf products rather than custom or open-source code. The financial management system reaches central and local government and covers treasury operations and budget preparation, but tracks programme performance only for selected programmes. In the Ibrahim Index, tax and revenue mobilisation and budgetary and financial management both fell over 2014-2023, to 20th and 24th of 54 African states (2023), so the fiscal institutions those systems serve weakened as they were built.

Line ministries run systems of uneven depth. Tax runs on TaxPro Max, with businesses above ₦5bn turnover required to integrate their invoicing since 1 August 2025 and medium taxpayers onboarding from July 2026, and every licensed payment solution provider and switch has had to integrate with the central bank's transaction monitoring system since March 2026. Justice moved fastest: electronic filing at the Supreme Court has been compulsory since 1 July 2026 under new practice directions requiring searchable documents and electronic transmission of records of appeal, on a case management system launched that month. Health and education remain pilots: 100 of Lagos State's 326 primary healthcare facilities were on electronic medical records by May 2025, and Edo State's schools system covered 51 schools by 2025.

Whether they talk to anything is the open question. In Edo State school admission is entirely manual, the state education board has neither ongoing nor planned work on education-identity interoperability, and the birth-registration database is connected to no educational platform in the state. Federally, Nigeria has joined the Digital Public Goods Alliance and plans open-source deployments of OpenCRVS, DHIS2 and OpenMRS.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

Nigerians got a single front door to the federal state only on 30 July 2026, when the Government Service Portal was soft-launched as a single sign-on gateway to federal services, built by Galaxy Backbone with Korea's KOICA under the e-Government Master Plan 2.0 after piloting since 2025 with a limited set of agencies. Two months earlier the state had put a conversational layer in front of the same maze: GovGuide, a multilingual assistant built on Meta's open-source Llama model, launched in May 2026 to route citizens through federal service processes.

What can actually be transacted is narrower than the shopfront suggests. The national service portal is transactional rather than informational, meaning services can be completed through it; businesses and individuals can register, file and pay taxes online; electronic procurement publishes both tender notices and awarded contracts; and a social protection portal is in use. There is no government online employment or job-services portal at all, so the one transaction a young Nigerian is most likely to want from the state has no national channel. Publication has moved faster than delivery: the accessibility of public records is one of Nigeria's strongest indicators in the Ibrahim Index and among its largest ten-year improvements, while equal access to public services has barely moved over the same decade (2023).

Behind the counter, the federal estate is being pulled onto sovereign infrastructure: full rollout of a 1Gov cloud run by the state carrier Galaxy Backbone has begun, supplying storage, encrypted government mail, content management and electronic signature across ministries in order to cut reliance on foreign systems and recurrent costs.

States build what the centre does not. Lagos runs an AI chatbot on WhatsApp paired with a self-reporting evidence portal for domestic and sexual-violence survivors, a service with no federal equivalent.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Only two of Nigeria's 36 states and the Federal Capital Territory reached high digital maturity in the Nigeria Governors' Forum's July 2025 assessment of state readiness for digital public infrastructure; most sat at a moderate stage. The federal tier is pushing cost and assets downward: the National Population Commission has asked states to pay for the full state-wide rollout of electronic civil registration themselves (July 2026), and the Nigerian Communications Commission has leased its Enugu Digital Industrial Park and Learning Centre to the Enugu State Government on a 15-year lease both parties call temporary and reversible (August 2026).

Enugu is the largest sub-national digital build. It is funding a solar-powered, connected school in each of its 260 political wards from its own budget, allocating ₦266.7bn in 2025 and ₦198bn in 2026, with education taking 32.27% of the 2026 budget and no donor finance involved. Delivery is far behind: all 260 were promised for January 2026, but in May 2026 many were still incomplete and unequipped with pupils already resuming in them, roofs failed at three sites and a school at Mbu was demolished in July 2025 after failing integrity tests, and a ₦11.4bn contract for 22 of the schools, on which ₦5.7bn was paid upfront, has been terminated, with ₦1.23bn recovered by the Economic and Financial Crimes Commission so far (May 2026).

Elsewhere the sub-national digital state is a scatter of systems rather than a tier. Anambra's in-house AI suite, SmartGov, checks local government payroll and spending against the national identity and bank-verification registers across its 21 local government areas (June 2025); Lagos is fixing QR-coded address plates linked to verified property data under the Lagos Identity Project, piloted in Eti-Osa and intended for all 57 local governments (June 2025); and Cross River has approved a state-wide smart surveillance network whose announcement names no lawful basis, retention period or oversight arrangement for the face and licence-plate data it would collect (July 2026). The one national system reaching the lower tier is financial: the government financial management information system is deployed at local as well as central government level (2025).

Rural digital data capture

Rural Nigeria's median mobile download speed was 16.4 Mbps in March 2026, its median upload 9.0 Mbps, up 47.5% on September 2025, on a crowdsourced test base that had roughly doubled to 543,123. The rural network is measured a great deal better than what happens on it is recorded.

Digital capture in 2026 mostly happens one or two administrative levels above the event it records. Rural primary healthcare clinics take the point-of-care record on paper, with the electronic reporting systems operating at higher administrative levels rather than at the clinic; rural primary schools mark attendance on paper forms that are digitised further up the chain rather than entered at the school; and field registrars in rural and hard-to-reach areas revert to paper when the network fails. The exceptions run through people carrying devices rather than institutions holding systems: young children's births are registered digitally by registrars on handheld devices under the national electronic civil registration rollout, and a donor-supported Edo State programme tracked attendance and performance in real time at a small number of schools, some of them rural, by 2025. Nigeria's rural policy framework is the best-scoring part of its showing on the Mo Ibrahim Foundation's 2024 governance index, 18th of 54, and its support to the rural economy is the country's fifth-best placing on any measure there, up 13.0 points over the decade to 2023 — a policy well ahead of the record it keeps.

Niger State had 21 NIN enrolment centres for a population of about 7.5 million in January 2026, a round trip to one costing around ₦3,000, and without a NIN a woman cannot reach the maternal care funded by the Basic Health Care Provision Fund; rural women's phone ownership stood at 42% against 78% in urban areas. That sits against rural communities' far lower rate of internet access. The constraint runs the other way too: poor rural broadband limits the reach of GovGuide, the AI assistant aimed at rural and low-literacy users, so the population it was built for is the one least able to reach it.

Technology

AI

The artificial intelligence actually running in Nigeria sits in the banks, and arrived before the regulator did: 87.5% of the fintechs the Central Bank of Nigeria surveyed were already using AI for fraud detection (June 2025), a year before the Bank launched its own machine-learning system for real-time fraud detection (June 2026) under its Payments System Vision 2028 programme.

There is no AI statute. What exists is a National Artificial Intelligence Strategy, published in 2024 through NITDA's National Centre for Artificial Intelligence and Robotics, and bills that have gone no further than second reading. On published frameworks the country does well: 38th of 135 countries and first in Africa on the 2026 Global Index on Responsible AI. The data-protection commission has taken deepfakes and synthetic media to an international enforcement working group of more than 60 regulators, pressing watermarking (March 2026).

Deployment outside finance is a scatter of services. GovGuide, launched in May 2026, answers government-service questions in English, Hausa, Igbo and Yoruba, built with Meta, NCAIR and Publica AI on the open-source Llama model. N-ATLAS, an open-source model for Yoruba, Hausa, Igbo and Nigerian-accented English, was fine-tuned on more than 400 million tokens by Awarri with NITDA and NCAIR (September 2025) on Meta's Llama-3 8B, and Awarri now anchors the GSMA's ATLAS Umoja initiative with five African governments (August 2026). Airtel gives subscribers a free spam-detection alert service (March 2025), Lagos runs a chatbot for domestic and sexual-violence survivors, and the national social register was widened using AI, satellite imagery and telecoms data (June 2025).

What is planned and not running matters as much. The DPI Framework and the AI Strategy both provide for artificial intelligence inside the national data exchange, and no AI function is operating in the NGDX platform (2025). The heaviest state use is surveillance, where researchers found little evidence of crime reduction and minimal use of camera footage in prosecutions (March 2026), and Cross River's approved specification puts facial recognition, number-plate reading, violence detection and flood monitoring onto a command centre domiciled in the Office of the State Security Adviser rather than a civil department.

ICT Industry

The line between Nigeria's banks and its technology companies has closed from both directions. Flutterwave took a microfinance banking licence in April 2026 after acquiring Mono, and Paystack bought Ladder Microfinance Bank in January 2026 and restructured under The Stack Group, jointly owned by its chief executive, Stripe and employees; meanwhile the tier-one banks keep their payments infrastructure inside their own groups — GTCO's HabariPay, Access Holdings' Hydrogen, Stanbic IBTC's Zest — so the Central Bank has begun regulating fintech ownership as well as fintech conduct (August 2026).

Payments is where the domestic industry is deep, and it thins quickly outside it. Nigeria's core federal systems run on commercial off-the-shelf software, and no global hyperscaler operates a full cloud region in the country, their African regions having gone to Kenya and South Africa instead. The counter-move is recent and explicit: the federal payroll and personnel system has been migrated to SoftSuite, built by the Nigerian firm Soft Alliance, which the Head of the Civil Service places under the Nigeria First Policy as cutting dependence on foreign software licences (July 2026). Hardware is starting at the edges, with Terra Industries holding a joint venture with the Defence Industries Corporation of Nigeria to localise production of drones, robotics and cybersecurity capability (2026). All of it sits inside an export base among the most concentrated on the continent: Nigeria ranked 49th of 54 African states for economic diversification on the Ibrahim Index in 2023, down over the preceding decade.

Where the tooling is foreign, the effect shows up in the work. A study of 21 Nigerian filmmakers found that unequal access to subscription generative-AI tools reinforces rather than closes Nollywood's split between high-budget productions aimed at cinema and global streaming and low-budget productions oriented to domestic streaming and YouTube (August 2026). The same work found models trained predominantly on Global North data producing cultural misplacement and stereotyping, and the tools substituting informal pre-production labour rather than creative roles, eroding the relational economies that have sustained Nollywood's workforce. The supply of people is not the constraint: Nigeria holds Africa's largest developer community.

Innovation ecosystem

The Nigerian Communications Commission has admitted building something and never switching it on: a digital industrial park and learning centre it financed in Enugu, meant for outsourcing, startup incubation and skills training, was never activated, its Executive Vice Chairman Aminu Maida saying that completing physical infrastructure is only the beginning and that buildings alone do not create innovation. The site has now passed to the Enugu State Government on a lease both parties call temporary and reversible (August 2026).

The private ecosystem has the opposite shape — wide and shallow. A 2026 national assessment by the Innovation Support Network identifies over 190 actively operating hubs and more than 250 active or partially active spaces across all six geopolitical zones, concentrated in Lagos and Abuja, the largest such ecosystem in Africa, and Nigerian startups raised just over US$400 million in 2024, keeping the country among the four African markets that take more than 80% of continental venture capital. None of that reaches the measured output: Nigeria ranks 113th of 133 economies on WIPO's Global Innovation Index 2024.

The instruments exist and are mostly untested against those numbers. The Nigeria Startup Act 2022 provides the statutory framework for startup labelling, regulatory sandboxes and tech-hub support, a National Blockchain Policy adopted in 2023 covers blockchain adoption and emerging-technology sandboxes, and Itana, in the Lekki Free Zone corridor, runs as a digital free zone offering remote incorporation on the Delaware and Dubai Internet City model at $2,000 to incorporate and $1,150 a year to renew (June 2025). Inside government the apparatus is half-built: the World Bank's 2025 assessment credits Nigeria with a public-sector innovation institution or an innovation strategy, but not both.

Absorption is being subsidised where the state can reach it — Galaxy Backbone and NITDA's innovation office supply discounted sovereign cloud to startups in the iHatch programme (May 2026) — and bought where it cannot, with Huawei, in Nigeria since 1999, opening an innovation centre in Lagos in May 2025. Underneath all of it sits the electricity supply, which Nigerian technology firms name as their main operating constraint.

Capacity

Literacy

Nigeria's answer to a population that cannot read its systems is increasingly to build systems that do not need reading: an AI assistant answering government-service questions in Nigerian languages as well as English, pitched explicitly at rural, low-literacy and multilingual users (May 2026) and, in schools, training teachers in AI before the pupils have the underlying skills. The floor beneath both has not been measured for five years: about 9% of Nigerians had used a computer in the previous three months (2021), with basic digital skills reaching only around a third even among the tertiary-educated — that is the population every service portal, every payment rail and every classroom device in the country is being built for, and use divides sharply by sex, and again between town and country, so the national figure understates how far the floor drops in rural Nigeria.

The gap runs inside the state as well as outside it. Low digital literacy among health workers sits alongside unreliable power and connectivity as a persistent barrier to electronic health records (2026), which is a different problem from the one usually described: the systems are not only unread by citizens, they are unoperated by the staff meant to run them.

The state-level response pulls the other way, and is capital rather than software: Enugu is building hundreds of smart schools from its own budget, with delivery behind the timetable the state itself set and pupils resuming in buildings still incomplete and unequipped (May 2026). Neither approach yet touches the 2021 baseline, which remains the most recent national measure of whether Nigerians can use what is being built for them.

The school system feeding that population loses its ground at the entry gate: enrolment scores 38.7 of 100 in the Ibrahim Index, 29th of 54 African countries and up 0.9 points over the decade to 2023, against 69.6 for completion, 10th and up 1.2 — the problem is getting children into school, not keeping them there once enrolled.

Training and skills

Nigeria's Federal Ministry of Education signed terms of reference in July 2026 for a nationwide AI Teacher Capacity Development Programme covering about 11,700 teachers in the federal unity colleges, after a pilot in six of those colleges, one per geopolitical zone — and no cost, timetable, evaluation design or pilot data has been published for it (August 2026). A national teacher-training contract whose price and success measure are both unstated is the shape most of this sector takes. Those teachers sit in the fastest-moving part of the system: teacher supply and training scores 83.0 of 100 in the Ibrahim Index, 27th of 54 African countries and up 8.8 points over the decade to 2023, while education quality is rated 34th, up 3.5.

The federal instrument beneath it is NITDA's 3 Million Technical Talent programme, which registers participants through the National Identification Number and runs a national talent registry: skilling built as an enrolment exercise, with the identity system as its gate. For the civil service itself, Nigeria has both a strategy and a running programme for public-service digital skills, covering basic digital skills and data literacy, free to those taking them (2025).

The most active trainer in the country is not the education ministry but the data protection regulator. The NDPC opened a Virtual Privacy Academy in May 2025, having by then run more than 5,000 compliance assessments and 223 investigations, and runs a certification partnership with Mastercard aimed at the informal sector (May 2025); its two-year data-protection programme is financed by Meta under a 2025 court-approved settlement (June 2026), an African regulator paying for its own compliance ecosystem out of a US platform's settlement money.

Where training has been given buildings, the terms are thin. NITDA commissioned a National Cybersecurity Centre at Bayero University, Kano in May 2025, and drone and robotics laboratories run by a defence contractor are being placed inside Miva Open University's curriculum with nothing published on research ownership or dual-use content vetting (August 2026). Meanwhile tertiary institutions are drafting their own AI rules one by one, in the absence of a national framework (July 2026).

Research institutions

Nigeria produces language technology for itself, on foundations produced elsewhere. N-ATLAS, the Nigerian Atlas for Languages and AI at Scale, is an open-source multilingual model covering Yoruba, Hausa, Igbo and Nigerian-accented English, fine-tuned on more than 400 million tokens by Awarri Technologies with NITDA and NCAIR — and built on Meta's Llama-3 8B (September 2025). The adaptation is Nigerian; the model it adapts is not, and neither is the money behind the wider African-language research it sits alongside, which Google funds at continental scale through a hub for African languages (July 2025).

Formal research capacity is otherwise slight in what is established: the National Cybersecurity Centre commissioned at Bayero University, Kano in May 2025 is presented as a national asset for cyber education, research and talent development.

Inclusion

Access to services

Surveys of Nigerian banks by the Association for the Blind in Nigeria and the Centre for Infrastructural and Technological Advancement for the Blind find most mobile banking apps, USSD channels and ATMs unusable for blind and low-vision customers — screen-reader incompatibility, unlabelled buttons, timed USSD menus and facial-recognition steps — with some made to sign indemnity forms to obtain an ATM card (2026).

The obligation is already on the books. The Discrimination Against Persons with Disabilities (Prohibition) Act 2018 covers banks, and Central Bank ATM guidelines require at least 2% of machines to carry tactile graphic symbols within five years of release, and accessibility is now a testable requirement for citizen-facing government platforms.

Where access widens, a condition comes with it. Every eligibility option in the Nigerian Communications Commission's June 2026 consultation on zero-rated access to educational platforms requires users to register. Identification is the other condition, now running through nearly everything: a working number is required for healthcare, education, banking, employment, telecoms and welfare, registering a newborn requires a parent to hold one, and the social register's own linkage to the identity system is unfinished, so qualifying for a service and being able to obtain it have come apart. Over the decade to 2023 the Ibrahim Index had Nigeria 21st of 54 African states on the equal distribution of access to public services, a score that rose 1.1 points, while Nigerians rated the difficulty of obtaining an identity document among the country's worst and most deteriorated measures in the same index.

Access to money has moved fastest at the top. Retail equity trading rose 138.76% in January to May 2026 against the same months of 2025, at ₦1.20 trillion, and retail investors account for 36.22% of trading on the Nigerian Exchange, bought through phone apps at ticket sizes as small as ₦5,000. At the other end, most bank account-holders have no access to credit. What is built against that gap borrows the informal sector's shape: Rank has taken the rotating ajo and esusu savings circle into a licensed product with a fixed fee and a guarantee on payouts.

Digital divides

A 2024 policy of the identity commission routes every correction to a National Identification Number record through a device-locked smartphone portal, which shuts out the roughly 72% of Nigerian adults who own no smartphone and has put a price on the workaround: agents charge ₦12,000 to ₦62,000 against an official fee of ₦2,000 (March 2026).

The line that draws is the one the survey record already describes. About 12% of Nigerian men and 6% of women had used a computer in the previous three months, and the intersection is sharper than either figure: 1.7% of rural women and 4% of rural men against 12% of urban women and 21% of urban men (2021). On GSMA's 2024 reading, 52% of adult men used mobile internet against 33% of women, a 19 percentage point gap, with a 38% gender gap in smartphone ownership behind it. Men also outnumber women on the identity register (June 2025), so the same asymmetry now sits inside the credential that gates the services.

Geography stacks on top of it, over a distribution of opportunity that has barely shifted: Nigeria ranks 41st of 54 African states for equal socioeconomic opportunity in the Ibrahim Index, a score that rose 1.5 points across the decade to 2023. Only 23% of rural communities had internet access against 57% of urban communities (October

2025), and the Universal Service Provision Fund carries 87 clusters of unserved and underserved areas holding about 23 million people (March 2026). State-level readiness for digital public infrastructure is itself uneven, so a person's state and settlement decide much of what reaches them.

Signal is not the binding constraint. About 109 million Nigerians were online at the end of 2025, 45.5% of the population, while the regulator's own population-coverage series runs far above that on every generation but 5G. The distance between where a network reaches and who uses it is made of devices, money and skill rather than masts, and that is the distance the divide sits in — the same index rates Nigeria's internet use, affordability and device ownership far below its mobile network (2023).

Data

National statistics

The weakest part of Nigeria's statistical system is not what it publishes but what it collects: the World Bank's Statistical Performance Indicators put the data sources pillar in the 20-49% band for 2023, the lowest of the index's five pillars for Nigeria, against 70-89% for data use and data products and 50-69% for data services and data infrastructure.

No business or establishment survey was conducted in the ten years to 2023, though agricultural, health and household surveys ran three or more times in that decade and the labour force survey twice, and no economic or business census fell inside the preceding twenty years, against an agricultural census and a population census that did. A state that has not counted its firms in two decades is legislating tax and industrial policy against a sector it has never enumerated.

The population count is older still. Nigeria has not held a census since 2006, and the National Population Commission was preparing the country's first biometric count — fingerprint, face and iris — to settle the figure-inflation disputes that dogged previous rounds (March 2025). Civil registration carries the shortfall into daily administration: about 57% of births and under 20% of deaths are registered, against roughly 5 million births a year (July 2026), weeks after the national electronic civil registration platform went live nationwide.

What the state counts best is money. Nigeria's Revenue Service collected ₦27.1 trillion (about $19.93bn) in the first seven months of 2026, 95.76% of its whole 2025 total and 66.57% of its ₦40.71tn target, and the National Bureau of Statistics puts the information and communication division at 11.31% of real GDP in the first quarter of 2026, up from 10.59% a year earlier, with telecommunications and information services alone at 9.19%.

Comparability inside official series is not assured. The December 2025 edition of the Communications Commission's urban-rural network analysis used a different tile definition from the March 2026 edition — more than 200 tests per tile, giving an urban median download of 20.5 Mbps against a rural 11.0 Mbps — so the two cannot be drawn as one trend line.

Open data

What Nigeria publishes openly is what the money system needs. Open Data Watch's 2024 inventory scores the economic and financial categories highest — 7 out of 10 for balance of payments, government finance, trade, and money and banking, and 6.5 for national accounts, while the weakest are environmental, with agriculture and land use at 3.5 and the built environment at 5, against 5.5 for energy and natural resources.

Between them sit the statistics people live on: social statistics run from poverty at 6.5 and education outcomes at 6 down to food security at 4 and education-facility and health-facility data at 4.5 — the facility-level data an administrative system generates as a by-product of running scoring lowest of all.

The legal frame is not the binding constraint. The Freedom of Information Act 2011 establishes a statutory right of access to records held by public institutions, the 2025 GovTech assessment rates that right effective rather than inoperative, and the electronic procurement system publishes tender notices and awarded contracts.

What goes missing is the individual document. The gazetted text of the NIMC Act 2026 had still not been made publicly available at 29 July 2026, six weeks after presidential assent, and the circular by which the Federal Government is said to have ordered ministries to comply with the data protection law could not be found on the Secretary to the Government's own portal, which did not answer a written request to explain why. Nigeria rates well on records even so: accessibility of public records ranks 6th of 54 in Africa in the Ibrahim Index, up 14.5 points over the decade to 2023, while disclosure ranks 23rd, up 3.5 points over the same decade.

The most consequential closure is not Nigerian. Appendix 5 of the United States-Nigeria health memorandum of understanding, the Data Sharing Agreement, is withheld rather than merely unpublished: the State Department put a subset of the memoranda online in March 2026, then removed public access, and published neither the rest nor the related agreements, leaving which Nigerian health systems the United States may reach, and on what terms, off the record.

Use of satellite data

Earth observation has one established use in Nigerian administration: satellite imagery, telecoms data and artificial intelligence were used to identify urban slum households and expand the national social register (June 2025).

Otherwise satellite in Nigeria means connectivity rather than observation, and the traffic runs the other way — from the sky down, not from the ground up. Starlink became the country's second-largest internet service provider by the fourth quarter of 2024, growing from about 23,900 subscribers to about 65,600 over the year, a rank held on a base small against mobile broadband, and one it could not immediately extend: Starlink paused new orders in parts of Lagos and Abuja in September 2025 because of network congestion. A competitor is licensed but not yet serving, the Communications Commission having granted Amazon's Project Kuiper a landing permit for satellite operations in January 2026. Satellite subscribers now sit inside the identity regime as well, required to attach a National Identification Number and a headshot to their accounts by December 2025.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

Nigeria's specimen sharing agreement with the United States reaches past specimens into the rest of the country's health diplomacy: Article 4(a) provides that Nigerian participation in any multilateral access-and-benefit-sharing arrangement, including surveillance and laboratory networks, shall not prejudice compliance with the agreement, and Article 4(b) restates the parent memorandum's term that failure on these commitments could bring changes to planned US assistance, discontinuation of the memorandum or termination of the agreement. What runs the other way is thinner: acknowledgement of the Federal Government and its institutions in publications and reports, a stated intent to share associated findings, and priority access to any countermeasure developed primarily from Nigerian material, that last subject to the availability of funds and applicable law. The agreement has been in force since 18 January 2026.

The appendix that would show which Nigerian health systems the United States may reach is not public, and the terms of the wider bargain are being pursued through an American court: Nigeria is one of sixteen countries in Public Citizen v. United States Department of State, filed in the District of Columbia on 2 April 2026, and the Nigeria Request submitted on 22 December 2025 seeks the health memorandum, its appendices, the data sharing agreement, the specimen agreement and the financing agreements, with budget tables and implementation plans.

The commercial footprint is shallower than the diplomatic one. No global hyperscaler runs a full cloud region in Nigeria, Amazon serving the country from Cape Town and from edge infrastructure, which sharpens the Data Protection Commission's refusal to treat the United States as an adequate destination for personal data. American money in the network build is a feasibility grant for the fibre backbone. The lever Nigeria has used on the platforms is competition law rather than data law: the Federal Competition and Consumer Protection Commission opened a probe into Meta, Alphabet, X and generative-AI platforms on a federal directive of 10 July 2026, and its 2025 penalty against Meta is under appeal, while the Data Protection Commission's own two-year privacy programme is financed out of Meta settlement money.

China activities

Cross River State specified its state-wide smart surveillance system after technical engagements with Huawei that included an inspection of the company's facilities in China, and will implement it through Huawei's local partner Dubass Synergy Multi-Services Limited (July 2026) — an addition to what is already Africa's largest AI surveillance estate (March 2026).

Chinese suppliers sit at both ends of the network. MTN Nigeria and Huawei lit the country's first 400G/800G hybrid optical network, in Lagos (October 2025); 21st Century Technologies has partnered China Mobile International to build local cloud and AI capacity (June 2026), so that the push to bring Nigerian data onshore runs on a Chinese stack; and Benue State's commitment to train its civil servants in digital tools builds on a skills partnership with Huawei (March 2025). Huawei has been in Nigeria since 1999 and opened an innovation centre in Lagos in May 2025, which the Minister of Communications, Innovation and Digital Economy publicly called "a catalyst for Nigeria's tech sovereignty", favouring local co-creation over technology consumption.

Beijing also built the regional seat that sits on Nigerian soil: the China-aid ECOWAS Headquarters Building in Abuja was formally handed over to the ECOWAS Commission on 28 April 2026, the second international-organisation office complex China has built in Africa. What Abuja says it wants next is not capital: at a UN workshop in Beijing in August 2026, Nigeria's Permanent Representative to the UN, speaking for President Tinubu, said the country seeks not financial assistance from China but access to geophysical and nautical data, technology transfer and investment for its marine economy.

EU activities

Nigeria's identity system is built on European credit: the European Investment Bank committed a US$215 million framework loan covering the eID platform and the supply of biometric identity to residents and to Nigerians living abroad (2025), and Agence Française de Développement holds a €100 million sovereign concessional loan to harmonise the national identification system so that every person in Nigeria can obtain a single unique official identifier (2026), both alongside World Bank money.

The same pattern holds in transmission. The EBRD has committed a sovereign loan of up to US$100 million to fund the Federal Government's participation in the vehicle that will roll out about 90,000 km of fibre as an open-access wholesale provider, targeting half of Nigeria's 33 million unserved people (2026), and the EIB earlier lent €100 million to expand 4G capacity, upgrade the core network and lift radio coverage in the Lagos region from 90% to 98% of the population (2022). The European Union committed €45 million in December 2025 under an EU–Nigeria digital economy package covering secure connectivity, subsea capacity, 5G and last-mile access, and returned in March 2026 with a Global Gateway package whose digital component co-finances the same fibre rollout with the EBRD and the country's data exchange work.

Europe is also inside the plumbing of the state. Nigeria and Team Europe are working jointly on the data exchange agenda (2025), the Nigeria Data Exchange having been built with the European Union, Finland and Estonia; Finland signed a memorandum on digitalisation in March 2026 prioritising cybersecurity, digital governance and digital infrastructure; Denmark's cBrain, with the Nigerian provider Publica AI, is deploying its case-management and workflow platform across federal ministries (January 2026); and the Nigerian Communications Commission and Swedfund signed a grant agreement for crowdsourced measurement of real-time network performance (February 2025).

Gulf/UAE activities

The Gulf's live interest in Nigeria's digital estate is a state government's, not the federal government's: Enugu State said in August 2026 that it is working with teams from Qatar to turn the digital industrial park it has leased from the Nigerian Communications Commission into a continental AI certification centre, and to convert the Digital Bridge Institute in the city into an AI institute.

The one closed transaction on record is older and private. Abu Dhabi's Mubadala made its first investment in an African-founded startup in Nigeria, leading a US$76 million financing round in 2023 for Moove, the vehicle-financing company that lends to ride-hailing drivers.

India activities

India approved a US$100 million line of credit to Nigeria for the establishment of a National Rural Broadband Network on 18 June 2019, with implementation managed by the Federal Ministry of Communications, and no other Indian-financed digital programme was running in Nigeria as at August 2026.

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